

but do have downloadable literature. Additionally, they allow downloads of their ads for use on your Web site.

So is online activism is restricted to social or environmental issues? Thanks to the media, no.

One of the strongest movements witnessed recently on the Net was against the forced closure of the blog 'Mediaah!' The blog, run by a journalist, carried daily updates about Indian media houses. Written in a chatty, gossip style, it gave out bits of 'insider' news on the activities of various big media houses. Its activities, though, were cut short since some of those mentioned on the site did not seem to agree with the views expressed.

According to the Indian IT Act, the respondent to the notice should have been the service provider—in this case, Google—and not the author. But, rather than challenge the notice, he decided to shut shop.

"This is a classic case of a large media house throttling our fundamental right of free speech," says Rohit Gupta, a journalist and a prolific blogger. Gupta and fellow bloggers from around the world are campaigning against blogs being attacked by entities with vested interests. "It's time these people realised that just because they have the muscle power they cannot trample upon our rights," says Gupta.

Thanks to the unregulated nature of the Internet, an anonymous blogger can potentially set up a blog called www.mediaha.blogspot.com with all the allegedly offensive articles, and also scanned copies of the legal notice served to Mediaah!

Not Just Petitions And Protests

So is it just about signing petitions and posting protests, or is there something concrete about the process? There definitely is a move beyond your desktop.

This is best illustrated by the amount of relief that flowed in during the tsunami of some months ago. Several blogs and Web sites were set up to coordinate relief work and dispense accurate information.

There is, however, only this much that any petition can do—whether posted online or distributed among people. To mobilise people, one needs to move from just spreading the word and gathering information.

All the relief work during the tsunami was possible because there were people on the ground who knew how to handle the situation. The Internet just acted as a facilitator; a one-point control centre. Can an issue be tackled only by protests lodged on the Net? "It depends entirely on the issue at hand," says Yashwant.

A customer-savvy corporation will pay attention to what its customers are saying. Companies like Microsoft have a cell to address consumer complaints and tackle issues that are posted on the Net. Likewise, e-friendly states with a high level of e-governance could look at incoming mails and stop an ill-advised project.

Morphed forms of activism on the Net are also gaining ground. One of the more popular



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ones is 'hacktivism'. This new phenomenon of protest in the cyber-world is a synthesis of social activism and hacking.

'Hacktivists' are a bunch of people who want to transport the movement of civil disobedience onto the Internet. In December 1999, a group called the Electrohippies organised a "WTO virtual sit-in" that overloaded the machines hosting

the World Trade Organisation's Web pages. Estimates say over 450,000 people swamped the site.

This disrupted traffic to the site for close to five hours daily. Some question whether it's an acceptable form of protest, but hacktivists hope to defuse criticism by popularising not just their tools, but also their code of ethics—by publicising their intentions before any attack or action.

It's All A Number Game

Over the last couple of years, online protests have garnered support from around the world. When the movements gained public acceptance.

In Bhopal, for example, on August 15, 1999, Greenpeace India launched its first cyber-protest. A cyber-café was set up in the middle of J P Nagar, literally in the shadow of the Union Carbide factory. Thousands of residents sent out e-mails from this facility.

After nearly 3,000 mails, Union Carbide was forced to shut down its corporate mail centre to screen out e-mails arriving from Bhopal. The case recently got a boost when, after a sustained e-mail campaign, the Government of India gave the US courts a green signal to accept cases filed by Indians against Union Carbide.

With advancements in technology, it is only natural that each of man's ways of expressing and emphasising his individuality will adapt with time. Protests are a way of pushing for and stressing one's rights. There has been a fundamental shift in the way protests are carried out.

But with effectiveness failing to back up the numbers, purists are still wont to describe online activism as all bark and no 'byte'. ■

mithun_kidambi@thinkdigit.com

? The Quirkies

With the Internet, it's not difficult to run into stuff that will have you laughing silly. It's no different with online petitions. Here's one:

☐ "Put The Star Wars Kid In Star Wars III"

This is addressed to George Lucas, the creator of the 'Star Wars' series.

☐ Who is the 'Star Wars Kid'?

He is a 15-year-old from Quebec. Back in November 2002, while playing around at a school video studio, the boy recorded himself fighting a mock battle using a broomstick as a lightsaber. The two-minute video has the teenager twirling his mock lightsaber while making his own accompanying sound effects.

His friends found the tape and uploaded it to KaZaA as a joke. Within two weeks, someone had added the gamut of Star Wars special effects and sounds to the tape, and the video was linked on gaming, technology, and Star Wars-related sites across the Internet.

☐ Now What?

This petition, up on www.petitiononline.com, has garnered close to 150,000 signatures. Will we see more of him?